

Jollof Rice for Everyone

Diaspora Fundraising in Innsbruck, Austria — Flood Relief to Onyah Community, Delta State, Nigeria

€1,000+ Raised in Innsbruck	2 Countries (AT + NG)	Boat Only Access to Community	4 Items Distributed
--------------------------------	--------------------------	----------------------------------	------------------------

Organisation	Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF)
Fundraising Partner	Dinners Club Innsbruck, Austria
Fundraiser	'Jollof Rice for Everyone' — community dinner, Innsbruck, January 2023
Amount Raised	Over €1,000
Needs Assessment	November / December 2022 — Onyah Community, Delta State
Relief Location	Onyah Community, Delta State, Nigeria
Access	By boat only — community surrounded by floodwater
Items Distributed	Rice · Onions · Tomato paste · Sanitary pads (for women and girls)

Overview — A Two-Continent Project

This project spans two continents and three phases. In November and December 2022, GDGF conducted a needs-based assessment visit to Onyah Community in Delta State, Nigeria — a community devastated by the 2022 floods and reachable only by boat. What the team found there drove a fundraising event in Innsbruck, Austria in January 2023, where GDGF partnered with Dinners Club Innsbruck to host 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' — a community dinner that raised over €1,000. Those funds were then deployed back to Onyah as food relief and sanitary pads for flood-affected families.

"We saw families living under tarpaulins on patches of dry sand, surrounded by water on all sides. Children. Elderly people. Women managing their periods with nothing. We went back to Innsbruck and we cooked jollof rice for everyone."

Background — Nigeria's 2022 Floods

Nigeria experienced its worst flooding in over a decade in 2022. By October 2022, the floods had affected 33 of Nigeria's 36 states, displacing over 1.4 million people and killing more than 600. Delta State was among the most severely affected, with communities along the Niger River and its tributaries completely submerged. Onyah Community — a rural Delta State community — was one of those cut off by rising floodwater.

Communities like Onyah — accessible only by boat — received little or no formal relief from government or large agencies. GDGF found them first.

Phase 1 — Needs Assessment, Onyah Community (Nov/Dec 2022)

Before taking any action, GDGF conducted a first needs-based assessment visit to Onyah Community in November/December 2022. The team reached the community by boat — the only means of access across the surrounding floodwater — wearing life jackets. What they found was a community in acute distress: families sheltering under makeshift tarpaulin structures on patches of dry sand, with no dry land in sight, no food security, and no menstrual products for women and girls.

What the Assessment Found

- Families displaced from their homes and farming land
- Makeshift tarpaulin shelters on sandy ground surrounded by water
- Children without adequate clothing or shelter
- Women and girls without access to menstrual products
- No reliable food supply — all agricultural land submerged
- Community reachable only by boat

GDGF's evidence-based model means the relief package — food items and pads — was chosen based on what the team actually observed in Onyah, not assumed from a distance.

Phase 2 — 'Jollof Rice for Everyone', Innsbruck (January 2023)

In January 2023, GDGF partnered with Dinners Club Innsbruck to host 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' — a community fundraising dinner in Innsbruck, Austria. Dinners Club Innsbruck is a community dining initiative with an established membership; they provided the venue, the community, and the event framework. GDGF brought the food, the story, and the cause.



Guests at the 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' fundraiser dinner, Innsbruck



Attendees gathered around the table for the fundraising dinner

The Dinners Club Partnership Model

The event operated on a clear and transparent revenue model: the Dinners Club invited their community to a dinner where GDGF cooked Nigerian jollof rice. Guests ate, drank, and heard GDGF's presentation about Onyah Community and the flood crisis. They participated in activities and donated.

The revenue from drinks sales went to Dinners Club as the hosting partner; the balance of donations after deducting food costs was transferred to GDGF for the Onyah relief project.

The Model Step by Step

- Dinners Club invites their Innsbruck community
- GDGF cooks jollof rice — Nigerian food as cultural bridge
- GDGF presents: who are the people of Onyah? What happened to them?
- Fun activities, eating, drinking
- Guests donate
- Drinks revenue → Dinners Club
- Balance after food costs → GDGF Onyah relief fund



Fried plantain prepared for the 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' fundraiser dinner — Nigerian cuisine as cultural bridge



Volunteers/ GDGF team members at the fundraiser dinner, selfie at the pink-tablecloth table



Community members at the fundraiser dinner, selfie at the pink-tablecloth table

Food is diplomacy. Jollof rice is arguably Nigeria's most universally recognised cultural export. By naming the fundraiser after the dish being served, GDGF created an event that was simultaneously a cultural experience, a community dinner, and an act of humanitarian advocacy.

Phase 3 — Relief Delivery, Onyah Community (2023)

Funds raised at the Innsbruck event were used to purchase and deliver relief items to Onyah Community. The team returned by boat — the only route available — carrying rice, onions, tomato paste, and sanitary pads for women and girls.

The inclusion of sanitary pads alongside food items reflects GDGF's understanding that menstrual health is not a secondary concern during a crisis — it is part of basic humanitarian need. In humanitarian emergencies, menstrual health is routinely deprioritised in relief packages. GDGF did not deprioritise it.

Women and girls displaced by flooding still menstruate. Distributing pads alongside food recognises the full spectrum of need — and is consistent with GDGF's core mission from its very first programme in 2016.

Outcomes and Impact

First Needs Assessment Confirmed Targeted Response

By visiting Onyah Community before acting, GDGF ensured its relief package addressed what was actually needed — food and menstrual products — rather than what was assumed. The

assessment also produced photographic and observational evidence that made the Innsbruck fundraising compelling and credible.

Over €1,000 Raised from the Austrian Diaspora Community

A community dinner in Innsbruck generated over €1,000 for a Nigerian flood relief project — demonstrating that GDGF can mobilise European diaspora funding through a replicable, culturally engaging model.

Flood-Affected Community Reached Despite Physical Inaccessibility

Onyah Community was only reachable by boat across floodwater. GDGF's team wore life jackets and crossed by boat twice — for the assessment and the delivery. This is direct-access humanitarian work, not remote programming.

Food and Menstrual Health Needs Addressed Simultaneously

Rice, onions, and tomato paste addressed acute food insecurity. Sanitary pads addressed menstrual health needs that humanitarian agencies routinely overlook. GDGF treated both as equally essential.

Diaspora Fundraising Model Proven Replicable

The Dinners Club Innsbruck partnership — transparent revenue model, cultural food event, GDGF presentation, community donation — is a model that can be replicated with other diaspora community groups across Austria, Europe, and beyond.

Project Timeline

Phase	Date	Activity
1 — Assessment	Nov/Dec 2022	Needs-based assessment visit to Onyah Community by boat. Documented: tarpaulin shelters, displaced families, food insecurity, no menstrual products.
2 — Fundraising	January 2023	'Jollof Rice for Everyone' — community dinner at Dinners Club Innsbruck, Austria. Over €1,000 raised.
3 — Relief Delivery	2023 (post-event)	Rice, onions, tomato paste and sanitary pads delivered to Onyah Community by boat. Team wore life jackets.

The Dinners Club Model — Replication Guide

The 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' fundraising model is one of GDGF's most replicable innovations. Key elements:

- Host partner with an existing community (eliminates need to build an audience from scratch)
- GDGF cooks — food is the cultural bridge, the conversation starter, and the fundraising hook
- GDGF presents directly — first-hand story from direct community visits, with photos
- Fun activities — social and enjoyable, not a guilt-driven charity appeal
- Transparent revenue split — drinks to host, food costs deducted, balance to project
- Low overhead — the host covers venue; GDGF's cost is ingredients

Potential to scale: This model could be replicated with diaspora community groups in Vienna, Graz, Salzburg, and other Austrian cities — and across European cities with Nigerian diaspora communities.

Learning and Recommendations

- The needs assessment before action model should be formalised as standard GDGF protocol for all emergency and relief programming.
- The 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' model should be documented as a replicable fundraising framework and offered to other Nigerian diaspora NGOs as a template.
- The Dinners Club Innsbruck partnership should be maintained and deepened — a second annual event would build a recurring revenue stream.
- Future relief packages should document the number of families and individuals reached.
- Including sanitary pads in the relief package should be formalised as a GDGF standard for all emergency relief programming.

Partners and Acknowledgements

- Dinners Club Innsbruck, Austria — for hosting the 'Jollof Rice for Everyone' event, providing the community platform, and enabling the fundraiser
- The guests who attended the Innsbruck dinner and donated — whose generosity crossed an ocean to reach Onyah Community
- The Onyah Community flood victims — for their resilience and for welcoming GDGF's team to their displaced homes
- GDGF team members who conducted the assessment visit and relief delivery by boat under challenging conditions